

Rhinoceroses

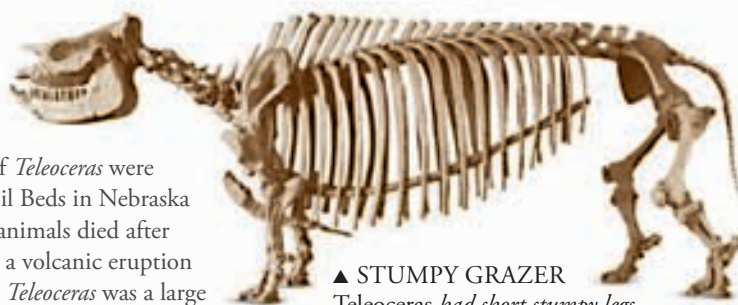
Today there are only five or six species of rhinoceros, all fairly similar. In prehistoric times the rhino family was much more varied, its members ranging from dog-sized animals to giants as tall as trees and heavier than any other land mammals. Some prehistoric rhinos were long-legged hornless animals built like horses for speed; others were short and fat and wallowed in water like hippos.

Teleoceras

TEE-lee-oh-SEE-rass

- **When** 17–4 million years ago
- **Fossil location** USA
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 13 ft (4 m)
- **Diet** Grass

Hundreds of complete skeletons of *Teleoceras* were found at Ashfall Fossil Beds in Nebraska (see next page). The animals died after choking on ash from a volcanic eruption 10 million years ago. *Teleoceras* was a large rhinoceros with a small, conical horn on its nose. But with its long, bulky body and stumpy legs, it looked more like a hippo than a rhino. Fossils have been found in ancient river and pond deposits, suggesting it wallowed in water a bit like a hippo, too.



▲ STUMPY GRAZER

Teleoceras had short stumpy legs and a barrel-shaped body. Its tall teeth were well suited to chewing grass, and fossilized grass seeds found in the throat of several skeletons show that grass was its main source of food.

Paraceratherium

PARRA-serra-THEER-ee-um

- **When** 33–23 million years ago (Late Paleogene–Early Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Pakistan, Kazakhstan, India, Mongolia, China
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 26 ft (8 m)
- **Diet** Plants

As big as a killer whale, this early hornless rhinoceros was the largest land mammal of all time. Its immense size and long neck allowed it feed on treetops, as giraffes do today. Its long, flexible lips could wrap around branches and strip the leaves off.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Large size
- Most had horns made from keratin (the same material that nails are made of)
- Large teeth for chewing leaves or grass
- Feet with hooves

When

Rhinoceroses first appeared in the Paleogene Period.

Coelodonta

SEE-low-DON-tah

- **When** 3 million–10,000 years ago (Late Neogene)
- **Fossil location** Europe, Asia
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 12 ft (4 m)
- **Diet** Grass

Also called the woolly rhino, *Coelodonta* had a thick coat of long, shaggy hair that protected it from the cold. It lived in Europe and Asia during the last ice age, and we know what it looked like thanks to frozen bodies found buried in icy ground (permafrost) and prehistoric cave paintings left by Stone Age people. About the size of a modern white rhino, its body was massive, with short, stocky limbs. On its snout was a pair of huge horns, each of a different size—the front horn was as long as 3 ft (1 m) in males. *Coelodonta* was a grazer, probably grinding mouthfuls of grass and other plants after tugging them out of the ground.

